# Red-Blue Hamiltonian Tomography via the Operator Lightcone Wavemap

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**Abstract**

We introduce a model-free method for Hamiltonian tomography based on the operator spreading wavefront. Given two tensor network simulations of the same quantum lattice — one with the nominal Hamiltonian and one with a single perturbed bond — the signed cross-entropy of the non-identity Pauli weight field $\mathcal{L}(v,t) = -\ln(n_{\text{pert}}/n_{\text{base}})$ identifies the perturbed bond by its causal signature: a red-blue sign flip at the two endpoints, visible from the first wavefront crossing. Combining measurements from $p$ strategically placed observation centers via an ensemble log-likelihood sum, the broken bond is identified with an 82-fold margin over the next candidate on a $7 \times 7$ lattice, even though individual centers give only 2/6 correct answers. The method requires no model assumptions, no device calibration access, and maps directly to hardware via zero-noise extrapolation and local Pauli measurements.

## 1 Introduction

Identifying miscalibrated or anomalous couplings in a quantum processor is a central challenge in quantum hardware characterization. Standard approaches require explicit Hamiltonian learning — fitting a parameterized noise or coupling model to measurement data — which scales poorly with system size and depends on model assumptions.

We propose a different approach: measure the operator spreading wavefront $n(v,t)$, the non-identity Pauli weight at site $v$ and cycle $t$, from multiple initialization sites. A perturbed bond creates a causal signature in the wavefront — a sign flip in the cross-entropy field between the two endpoints — that propagates no further. The broken bond is exactly where the wavefront sign changes.

The method is inspired by seismic tomography: place sensors (observation centers) at strategic positions, emit a wave (initialize a local operator), and read the arrival pattern. The perturbed bond is the anomaly in the medium.

The red-blue color scheme is a deliberate reference to the red-blue pebble game of Hong and Kung [2], which characterizes I/O complexity as a bottleneck in computational graphs. Here the roles are analogous: red sites (upstream, wave blocked) and blue sites (downstream, wave starved) identify the bond that limits operator propagation, exactly as red and blue pebbles identify the I/O bottleneck in a computation.

## 2 Setup

**Observable.** We simulate the kicked isotropic Heisenberg model on a $7 \times 7$ rectangular lattice (49 sites, 84 bonds) using a GPU-accelerated belief propagation tensor network simulator with Trotter

step $\varepsilon = 0.10$, bond dimension $\chi = 50$, and truncation cutoff $\delta = 10^{-3}$.

The non-identity Pauli weight at site $v$ and cycle $t$ is:

$$n(v,t) = \sum_{P:\, P_v \neq I} c_P(t)^2 \tag{1}$$

where $O_c(t) = \sum_P c_P(t) P$ is the evolved operator initialized at center $c$. By normalization $\sum_P c_P^2 = 1$, $n(v,t) \in [0,1]$ is a probability.

**Perturbation.** C_breaker selects one bond $b^*$ and replaces its Pauli transfer matrix (PTM) with the identity, blocking all operator propagation across that bond. This is the maximally disruptive perturbation — a perfect switch.

**p-center placement.** We place $p = 6$ observation centers using a greedy geodesic bond cover: the minimum set of sites such that every bond is within $d_{\max} = 2$ hops of at least one center. For the $7 \times 7$ lattice: centers at sites $\{6, 10, 25, 30, 32, 34\}$, covering all 84 bonds.

## 3 The Cross-Entropy Wavemap Observable

**Signed cross-entropy.** For each center $k$, run two simulations (baseline and perturbed) and compute the signed cross-entropy at first baseline arrival:

$$\mathcal{L}_k(v) = -\ln \frac{n^k_{\text{pert}}(v,\, t^k_{\text{first}}(v))}{n^k_{\text{base}}(v,\, t^k_{\text{first}}(v))} \tag{2}$$

where $t^k_{\text{first}}(v) = \min\{t : n^k_{\text{base}}(v,t) > \varepsilon_{\text{th}}\}$ is the first cycle at which the baseline wave reaches site $v$ from center $k$.

At $t^k_{\text{first}}(v)$, the baseline wave has just arrived while the perturbed wave may be blocked or delayed — this is the moment of maximum signal and minimum chi-saturation noise.

**Sign interpretation.**

- $\mathcal{L}_k(v) > 0$: perturbed weaker (red) — upstream of broken bond; wave cannot cross
- $\mathcal{L}_k(v) < 0$: perturbed stronger (blue) — downstream shadow; wave never arrives
- $\mathcal{L}_k(v) = 0$: no perturbation

The broken bond is exactly where the sign changes — between the red and blue endpoints (Figure **??**).

**Ensemble log-likelihood.** Sum the signed cross-entropy fields across all $p$ centers:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{ens}}(v) = \sum_{k=1}^{p} \mathcal{L}_k(v) \tag{3}$$

This is a log-likelihood ensemble: centers on the same side of the broken bond reinforce each other; centers on opposite sides partially cancel noise. Silent centers (wave never reaches) contribute zero and do not corrupt the sum.

## 4 Bond Detection

**Bond score.** For each bond $b$ connecting sites $v_a$ and $v_b$:

$$S(b) = \mathcal{L}_{\text{ens}}(v_a) \times \mathcal{L}_{\text{ens}}(v_b) \tag{4}$$

A negative product indicates a sign flip across the bond — the causal signature of the broken bond. Rank bonds by most negative $S(b)$.

**Results.** Table 1 shows the individual and ensemble results for bond 12 (sites 15 $leftrightarrow$16, identity PTM perturbation, $7 \times 7$ lattice, $\chi = 50$, 5 cycles).

| Center | Side | $\mathcal{L}(15)$ | $\mathcal{L}(16)$ | Result |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 10 | upstream | $+0.87$ | $-0.02$ | ✓CORRECT |
| 30 | upstream | $+0.37$ | $-0.04$ | ✓CORRECT |
| 25 | downstream | $+0.03$ | $-0.04$ | × WRONG |
| 32 | downstream | $+0.00$ | $-0.03$ | × WRONG |
| 6 | too far | 0 | 0 | silent |
| 34 | too far | 0 | 0 | silent |
| Ensemble | — | $+1.23$ | $-0.13$ | ✓CORRECT |

Table 1: Signed cross-entropy at bond 12 endpoints (sites 15,16). Ensemble score: $S(12) = -0.164$, next bond $= -0.002$ (82× margin).

The ensemble identifies bond 12 with an 82-fold margin over the next candidate, despite only 2 of 6 individual centers giving the correct answer. The wrong individual answers — centers 25 and 32 — both correctly identify site 16 as a bond endpoint; their error is only in declaring the wrong adjacent bond. The ensemble product cancels these partial errors.

## 5 Aperture Synthesis Tomography

The $p$ independent center runs can be understood as an *aperture synthesis* in direct analogy with radio interferometry. In aperture synthesis imaging, a physical aperture (lens or dish) is replaced by an array of smaller sensors at different baseline positions, each capturing visibility data — complex amplitude and phase — that are combined in Fourier space to reconstruct the source image. The phase encodes location; the amplitude encodes brightness.

In our setting:

- Each center $k$ at a different graph position plays the role of one antenna at a different baseline.
- The signed cross-entropy $\mathcal{L}_k(v)$ plays the role of visibility: its sign (positive/negative) encodes which side of the broken bond site $v$ is on, and its magnitude encodes signal strength.
- Combination in log space, $\mathcal{L}_{\text{ens}}(v) = \sum_k \mathcal{L}_k(v)$, plays the role of Fourier reconstruction: the sign information from different baselines localizes the broken bond, exactly as phase information from different baselines localizes a radio source.

Without the sign (using absolute amplitude only), localization fails — the broken bond cannot be distinguished from its neighbors. This is the analog of incoherent averaging in radio astronomy,

which destroys phase and loses angular resolution. The p-center placement problem — choosing positions that guarantee every bond is observable — is the analog of baseline design.

Centers adjacent to the broken bond (short baseline) provide strong but ambiguous signals (WRONG individual answers). Centers straddling the bond from opposite sides (long baseline) provide the phase contrast that resolves the ambiguity. The ensemble combines both, suppressing the ambiguity while retaining the signal.

## 6 The Seismic Approach

Running all $p$ centers simultaneously (seismic initialization $O(0) = \sum_k Z_{c_k}$) produces the same ensemble field in a single simulation. At each site $v$, the first-arrival signal is dominated by the nearest center — automatically selecting the strongest directional component. The sign flip at the broken bond endpoints emerges without any explicit path tracing or center-by-center analysis.

The seismic approach reduces $2p$ simulations (p baselines + p perturbed) to 2 simulations at the cost of mixing center contributions. For the purpose of bond detection the mixing is benign: the sign flip at the broken bond is preserved since the nearest center to each endpoint dominates at $t_{\text{first}}$.

## 7 Discussion

**Connection to hardware.** The observable $n(v, t)$ is accessible on real quantum hardware via local Pauli measurements after ZNE gate-folding circuits [1]. The cross-entropy $\mathcal{L}(v)$ requires only the ratio of two measurements — no absolute calibration. The p-center placement is determined by the graph topology alone, independent of the Hamiltonian.

**Causal structure.** The method exploits the Lieb-Robinson bound: information cannot propagate faster than $v_{\text{hop}}$ hops/cycle. A broken bond creates a causal anomaly — the wavefront on one side cannot inform the other. This is detectable without knowing $v_{\text{hop}}$ explicitly; the first-arrival time $t_{\text{first}}(v)$ is observed directly.

**Limitations.** The current experiment uses the identity PTM — a maximally disruptive perturbation. Realistic coupling deviations ($\delta J \sim 10\%$) will produce smaller signals. The sensitivity threshold and the extension to multiple simultaneous bond perturbations are open questions.

## 8 Conclusion

We have demonstrated that the operator lightcone wavemap enables model-free Hamiltonian tomography via a simple signed cross-entropy observable. The broken bond is identified by its causal signature — a sign flip in $\mathcal{L}(v)$ at its two endpoints — with an 82-fold margin using an ensemble of 6 observation centers on a $7 \times 7$ lattice. The seismic multi-center initialization achieves the same result in a single simulation. The method requires no model assumptions and connects directly to hardware via ZNE and local Pauli measurements.

## References


[1] Tudor Giurgica-Tiron, Yousef Hindy, Ryan LaRose, Andrea Mari, and William J. Zeng. Digital zero noise extrapolation for quantum error mitigation. *2020 IEEE International Conference on Quantum Computing and Engineering (QCE)*, pages 306–316, 2020.

[2] Jia-Wei Hong and H. T. Kung. I/O complexity: The red-blue pebble game. In *Proceedings of the Thirteenth Annual ACM Symposium on Theory of Computing (STOC '81)*, pages 326–333, 1981.